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INSIDE

IMMIGRATION ENFORCEMENT **PG. 2**

KAWEAH GROUNDWATER BASIN **PG. 7**

CA DETECTOR DOGS **PG. 9**

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GSA Roundup: June Briefing From Across the Basin

Groundwater policy may not make the headlines, but this month's GSA activity reveals just how much is shifting below the surface. From funding debates to coordination setbacks, here's what's happening across the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

Mid-Kings River GSA

Active discussions around funding, mitigation, and allocation reform.

At the June meeting, Mid-Kings GSA advanced its well mitigation program by confirming core components of eligibility, timelines, and funding structure. Institutional sites such as churches and schools were temporarily removed while revised language is developed.

The committee also supported a phased approach to reducing groundwater use across the service area, with implementation to begin in upcoming water years. A new subsidence map was reviewed, and the group agreed to proceed with a locally driven management plan, independent of pending state guidance. Budget planning discussions are underway, including how to support monitoring, staffing, and technical services needed to carry out these programs.

Tri-County Water Authority GSA

Positioning itself as a policy and coordination leader.

The Tri-County Water Authority Board approved the 2026 land-based and pumping assessments and finalized penalties for delinquent accounts and unregistered wells. The draft GSP, including a well mitigation plan, is on track for public release by July 21.

A major concern was the State Water Board's proposed SGMA fee structure. Under the plan, large pumpers could pay up to $40 per acre-foot, raising a total of $6.66 million, all from this subbasin. TCWA staff plan to submit a formal comment letter objecting to the disproportionate burden.

A domestic well mitigation program and meter reimbursement option are also in development.

South Fork Kings GSA

Facing pressure on both funding and representation.

The board approved next year's budget but acknowledged that fully implementing the Groundwater Sustainability Plan (GSP) will require additional funding. Key unfunded needs include domestic well mitigation, groundwater monitoring, and infrastructure tracking.

To cover the gap, the advisory committee discussed possible fee structures, including land-based assessments, pumping fees, and SGMA-authorized penalties for overuse. Any increase, they agreed, should be tied to clearly defined programs.

"GSA Roundup" continued on page 13

Why Your Voice Matters Now More Than Ever: SGMA Fee Proposals and the Future of Groundwater Management

by Julie Martella

The State is proposing major changes to SGMA groundwater fees, and Tulare Lake Subbasin stakeholders are in a critical window to weigh in. These changes are presented as equitable, but the numbers, structure, and accountability raise significant concerns.

In recent weeks, conversations with State staff and policy experts have confirmed what many stakeholders in the Tulare Lake Subbasin have long suspected: the State Water Board's SGMA fee structure is less about temporary enforcement and more about a system that lacks accountability, transparency, and balanced cost-sharing.

A New Fee Structure That Hits Small and Large Pumpers Alike

Since 2017, groundwater users in State-intervened areas have paid a flat rate of $300 per well plus $20 per acre-foot (AF) of groundwater pumped. The proposal being considered would replace this with a tiered system based on total extraction volume.

The new structure is intended to create more equity across users, but the early projections raise questions. The revenue forecast indicates that $6.66 million was collected from the Tule Subbasin alone, despite the SGMA program's annual budget of only $5.5 million.

The details of the proposed tiered fee structure are shown in the table above. The table outlines the proposed SGMA fee tiers by extraction volume, including estimated revenue and the number of extractors in each category.

Landowners who were previously exempt from

Potential Revised SGMA Fees

Extraction bracket (ac-ft)	Proposed Volumetric Fee ($)	Extractors	Projected Revenue ($M)
2 - 305	$5	3,556	$0.07
306 - 667	$9	297	$0.42
668 - 1,175	$14	152	$1.11
1,176 - 2,311	$24	85	$1.9
Greater than 2,311	$40	34	$3.18
TOTAL		4,124	$6.66

"Groundwater Management" continued on page 11

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

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Reliable | Trusted Resource

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Executive Director
Dusty Ference
dusty.ference@kcfb.org

Farm Life Advertising
Breanna Larman
blarman@kcfb.org
(559) 584-3557

Farm Life Designer
Beth Greene

CFBF District Representative
Kevin Robertson

Contact
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford, CA 93230
Phone: (559) 584-3557
www.kcfb.org

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

A note on SGMA and advocacy

By Dusty Ference, Executive Director

Dusty Ference

As your Executive Director, I would like to take a moment to acknowledge the critical juncture we've reached in implementing the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA) across the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

Right now, GSAs throughout our region are making difficult decisions, many of which are unpopular with growers. These decisions are not made lightly, and we understand the frustration many of you are feeling. At the same time, we also acknowledge the pressure GSAs face to comply with state mandates. These are complex issues without easy answers, and it's important to us that you know that KCFB hears and understands both perspectives.

The singular focus of KCFB's lawsuit is to challenge the decision made by the State Water Resources Control Board placing the Tulare Lake Subbasin on probation under SGMA. While the law of SGMA allows for probation, how the subbasin was placed on probation is not. We remain committed to challenging this regulatory overreach and defending the rights of local stakeholders to manage groundwater at the local level.

If you have concerns about what's happening at your GSA, we encourage you to contact us. We want to hear from you whether it's a question, a concern, or a specific idea you'd like the Board to consider. KCFB is a grassroots membership organization, and your voice matters. Member input helps guide the direction of our advocacy, ensuring we represent your interests effectively.

Please don't hesitate to contact our office or speak directly with a board member. We're here for you.

President Calls for Middle Ground Immigration Enforcement Policy for Ag and Hospitality

Contributed by Bryan Little, Farm Employers Labor Service

In a June 29 interview on Fox News' Sunday Morning Futures with host Maria Bartiromo, President Trump indicated the administration is working on a way to allow agricultural and hospitality employers to have a "temporary pass" to avoid negative impacts on their businesses from stepped-up immigration enforcement.

"I don't back away. What I do have, I cherish our farmers. And when we go to a farm and we take away people that have been working there for 15 or 20 years, who are good, who possibly came in incorrectly. And what we're going to do is we're going to do something for farmers where we can let that farmer sort of be in charge. The farmer knows he's not going to hire a murder. But you know, when you go into a farm and you set somebody working with them for nine years doing this kind of work, which is hard work to do and a lot of people aren't going to do it, and you end up destroying a farmer because you took all the people away," Trump said.

Trump continued, "It's a problem. You know, I'm on both sides of the thing. I'm the strongest immigration guy that there's ever been, but I'm also the strongest farmer guy that there's ever been, and that includes also hotels and, you know, places where people work, a certain group of people work. We're working on it right now. We're going to work it so that, some kind of a temporary pass, where people pay taxes, where the farmer can have a little control as opposed to you walk in and take everybody away."

The President's comments did not indicate an immediate shift in Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), Border Patrol, or DHS's enforcement posture, which Border Czar Tom Homan defined as, "The message is clear that we're going to continue to do worksite enforcement operations – even on farms and hotels but based on a prioritized basis. Criminals come first."

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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

AG NEWS IN BRIEF

Ted Cooke Nominated to Lead. Bureau of Reclamatoin

Last month, President Trump nominated Ted Cooke to serve as the next Commissioner of the Bureau of Reclamation (USBR), he will need Senate confirmation before assuming the role. Cooke previously spent two decades working at the Central Arizona Project, which is the state's largest water project. USBR helps handle many of the water delivery, storage, and energy projects in the western U.S. If confirmed, challenges around the management of the Colorado River are expected to be a significant area of focus for the next commissioner.

California Farm Bureau Joins Coalition Letter Urging Partnership on MAHA Commission

CAFB joined nearly 300 groups urging the Make America Healthy Again Commission to engage agricultural stakeholders. The Commission's recent report criticized pesticide use without consulting the industry, despite promoting U.S. produce. CAFB seeks to partner on future input.

California groundwater levels see another bump — but long-term trend still grim

California saw a notable bump in groundwater supplies last year, marking a second straight year that the crucial underground reserve wasn't drawn down by thirsty cities and farms, new state data shows. The groundwater report released Tuesday by the state's Department of Water Resources calls last year's boost in supplies a "positive outcome." However, it warns that "long-term trends continue to show widespread declines, particularly in the Tulare Lake and San Joaquin River hydrological regions." *San Francisco Chronicle.*

Opinion: California politicians ignore agriculture's troubles but boost movie business

Agricultural leaders see this year as one of the industry's most trying periods, beset by economic and political factors that could significantly reduce production. "When we talk about the things that are keeping me up at night, it really comes down to what is going to keep our members in business," Shannon Douglass, president of the California Farm Bureau, said, citing a federal census of agriculture that revealed California has lost 20% of its farmers in the last decade. Efforts by Gov. Gavin Newsom and legislative leaders to double state subsidies for the film industry imply politicians believe that producing movies is much more important than producing food. *CalMatters.*

Farms, hotels and restaurants press Trump to exempt their businesses from immigration raids

Farms, hotels and restaurants that rely on immigrant workers are urging the Trump administration to spare their vital industries from immigration raids. The pressure comes as confusion swirls around whether President Trump will exempt some businesses from efforts to arrest and deport immigrants living illegally in the United States. "The current approach to federal immigration enforcement is having a disruptive effect on California's rural communities and the farmers, ranchers, workers and families who live and work there," Bryan Little, senior director of policy advocacy at the California Farm Bureau, said. "Some farmworkers, fearful of raids — partly because of false alarms spread on social media — don't want to risk going to work, fueling a labor shortage," Little added. *Los Angeles Times.*

How AI and robot hives are lowering the risk of bee colony collapse in California

Lifting up the hood of a Beewise hive feels more like you're getting ready to examine the engine of a car than visit with a few thousand pollinators. … Inside sits a high-tech scanner and robotic arm powered by artificial intelligence. Roughly 300,000 of these units are in use across the U.S., scattered across fields of almond, canola, pistachios and other crops that require pollination to grow. ... The question is whether beekeepers are willing to switch out tried and true equipment. *Los Angeles Times.*

Food, agriculture leaders sound warnings on MAHA overreach

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. and his allies are increasing federal scrutiny of ultra-processed foods, additives, dyes and pesticides. But Chuck Magro, chief executive of pesticide and crop seed giant Corteva Agriscience, said at The Wall Street Journal's Global Food Forum in Chicago this week that agricultural chemicals are rigorously studied before farmers can spray them on fields. Magro added the chemicals currently used remain critical to American food production. "Farmers need those tools. This notion that they can farm without these products, it's just not accurate," he said. *The Wall Street Journal.*

Sites Project Update

Sites Project Authority has released its 2024 Annual Report that outlines past and future efforts toward the construction of Sites Reservoir. The report highlights a successful litigation defense in court, resulting in a ruling that confirmed the Final Environmental Impact Report complies with the requirements of the California Environmental Quality Act (CEQA). Significant progress has also been made in permitting and financing, as the Authority received Construction and Operation Permits from California Fish and Wildlife and is on track to receive its Water Rights Order and Permit from the State Water Resources Control Board. In terms of financing, Sites Reservoir recently received an additional $134 million in federal funding, which has helped make sure the project becomes a "reality." Looking ahead to 2025, the Authority plans to continue its outreach to contractors and land acquisition efforts, having already purchased approximately 2,000 acres. The Authority remains confident it will break ground in late 2026, ushering in a new era of water reliability, flexibility, and resilience. Preliminary designs and finance plans for the Reservoir are now available on their website. More information is available at *https://sitesproject.org/*.

CFBF Files Protest in PG&E GR Phase 1

On June 18, 2025, CAFB filed its protest to Pacific Gas & Electric Company (PG&E) General Rate Case (GRC) Phase 1 application. CAFB's protest focused on PG&E's misleading presentation of the impact of the case. For example, PG&E claims that bills will mostly be flat compared to 2025, but this looks at the GRC in isolation and without additional ongoing cases that will further impact rates. It also ignores the fact that PG&E does not include requests for funding to underground distribution lines outside of 2027 because of the shifting of that request to the SB 884 expedited underground program. This allows for billions of dollars to be left out of the calculus on impacts to customers despite knowing they will be requested and at least in some capacity granted. The next step in the proceeding will be the Prehearing Conference on July 3, 2025, and then CAFB will begin to further review testimony and explore opportunities to push back on funding requests.

The Kings County Farm Bureau distributes Ag News in Brief to its members only for information. Some story links may require website registration.
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Understanding Educational Needs of Dairy Industry During the Bird Flu Outbreak

Rúbia Branco-Lopes[1], Daniela Bruno[1], Betsy Karle[1], Randi Black[1] and Noelia Silva-del-Río[1,2]

[1]University of California Cooperative Extension, UC Agriculture and Natural Resources

[2]School of Veterinary Medicine, UC Davis

In 2024, Highly Pathogenic Avian Influenza (HPAI) H5N1, also known as bird flu, emerged as a new threat to dairy cattle. Nationwide, 1,074 cases were confirmed in cattle across 17 states. Recently, the number of new cases has declined; only one new case has been reported in California over the past 30 days. To better understand the dairy industry's educational needs regarding HPAI, UC Cooperative Extension (UCCE) conducted a survey in collaboration with the California Dairy Quality Assurance Program (CDQAP) and the California Milk Advisory Board (CMAB).

Respondents included 11 dairy producers (40.7%) and 16 allied industry professionals (59.3%). Producers represented a range of herd sizes: three had over 2,000 cows, five had 1,000 to 2,000 cows, and three had under 1,000 cows.

Before the outbreak reached California, only one-third of respondents (33.3%) felt well-informed about HPAI. Information was obtained through online channels such as webinars (63.0%), written materials such as newsletters or fact sheets (59.3%), and one-on-one conversations (70.4%) with trusted advisors, including veterinarians, nutritionists, UCCE, and peers.

Regarding preparation before the outbreak, most dairy producers had a treatment protocol (72.7%), acquired equipment and supplies to drench and treat cows (72.7%), provided biosecurity training for employees (72.7%), acquired personal protective equipment for workers (63.6%), and implemented enhanced biosecurity measures (63.6%).

Nearly 60% of respondents attended HPAI-related webinars hosted by UCCE, CDQAP, CMAB, and UC Davis. All these attendees considered the webinars informative. Overall, the three topics rated as most interesting were the HPAI overview (81.2%), producer perspectives (75.0%), and veterinarian perspectives (75.0%; Fig. 1).

When asked what topics they would like more training or information on, the top priorities among all respondents were the long-term health impacts of HPAI on lactating cows (73.1%), calves and heifers (65.4%), and vaccination updates (65.4%; Fig. 2). Among producers, the most selected topics were financial assistance programs (90.9%), long-term health impacts on calves/heifers (72.7%), and on lactating cows (63.6%), updates on HPAI transmission (63.6%), and treatment strategies (63.6%).

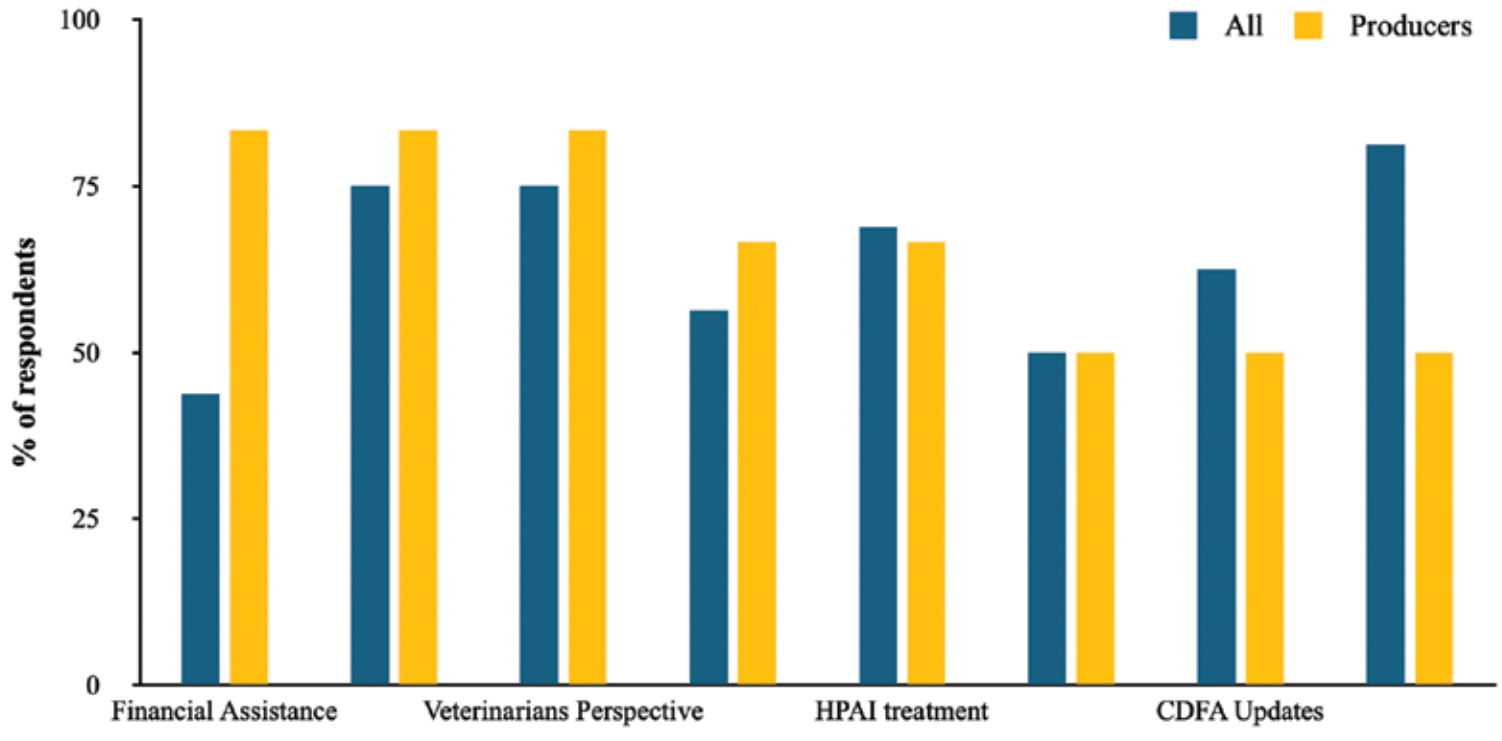

Figure 1. *Proportion of webinar attendees that rated topics as "very interesting". There were 16 attendees, and 6 of those were dairy producers.*

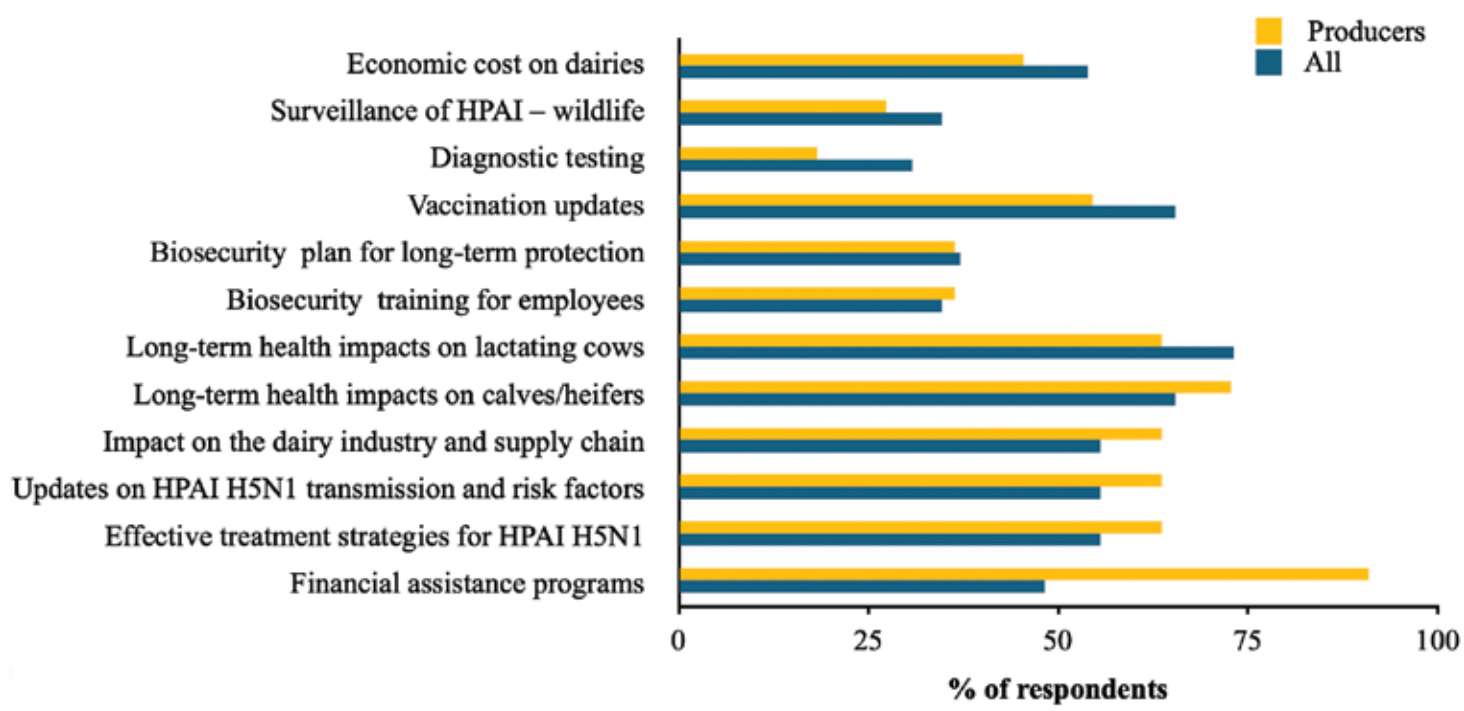

Figure 2. *Proportion of survey participants that would like to receive additional information on HPAI. There were 27 total respondents and of those 11 were dairy producers.*

UCCE will use this information to refine its outreach programs, with the goal of improving preparedness, strengthening biosecurity practices, and supporting the dairy industry's ability to respond to current and future challenges related to HPAI.

Acknowledgement: *We thank all survey participants for their contributions.*

SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

Kings County Farm Bureau's legal challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board has already saved growers in the Tulare Lake Sub-basin millions of dollars and kept state intervention off your farm. But the fight isn't over yet—and we need your support to finish strong. By contributing, you'll play a crucial role in securing a win for California agriculture, protecting farms, and ensuring the future of farming in California. This is a pivotal moment—your support can make all the difference.
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Kaweah is second San Joaquin Valley groundwater basin to escape state enforcement

Contributed by Lisa McEwen

Aaron Fukuda, interim manager of the Mid-Kaweah Groundwater Sustainability Agency, explains efforts in the Kaweah subbasin to stem over pumping during a June 27 workshop by the state Water Resources Control Board. Lisa McEwen / SJV Water

The Kaweah subbasin is the second San Joaquin Valley region to successfully escape state intervention, managers learned today.

In a phone call with state Water Resources Control Board staff, managers of Kaweah's three groundwater sustainability agencies got the news that their efforts to rewrite their groundwater management plans were good enough for staff to recommend that they return to Department of Water Resources oversight.

"I think the proof is in the pudding," said Aaron Fukuda, speaking on behalf of the East, Mid- and Greater Kaweah groundwater sustainability agencies. "We put everything we had into the development of the GSP, and now we will put all that energy into implementation."

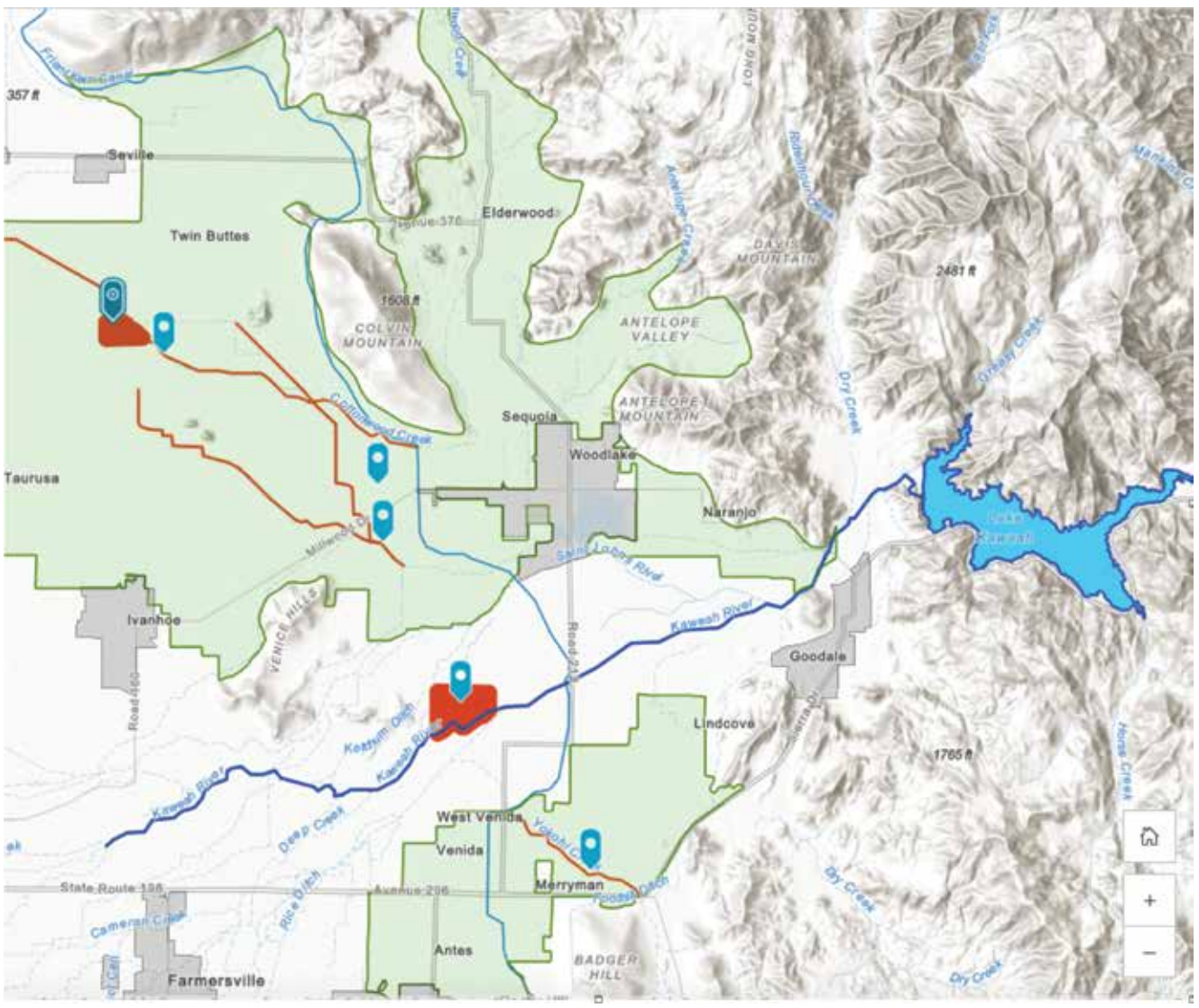
The Chowchilla subbasin successfully made the u-turn from state enforcement back to oversight in early June. Fukuda said Kaweah will follow much the same path as Chowchilla.

The Water Board will consider the staff recommendation for Kaweah at a meeting in the fall, when it can pass a resolution formally sending Kaweah back to DWR.

Returning to DWR oversight guarantees landowners freedom from additional fees under the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act, which mandates that overdraft stop and aquifers reach balance by 2040. Under probation, landowners would have to register wells at $300 each, install meters and pay $20 per acre foot pumped, on top of fees already paid to their irrigation and groundwater agencies.

That breathing room means a lot to landowners, who just a few years ago were in a subbasin wracked by disagreements over pumping allocations. The three groundwater agencies were at loggerheads and tense meetings pitted farmer against farmer.

Part of the challenge that continues to this day is that the East and Mid-Kaweah groundwater agencies have substantial amounts of imported surface water whereas a large chunk of Greater Kaweah has no surface water. Farmers in those areas are totally dependent on groundwater.



> *"We put everything we had into the development of the GSP, and now we will put all that energy into implementation."*
> **–Aaron Fukuda, interim manager of the Mid-Kaweah Groundwater Sustainability Agency**

But facing the spectre of probation, water managers, residents and landowners rewrote the region's plan to include aggressive pumping restrictions basin wide and ramped up the number of water recharge projects.

The efforts earned them first a delay and then a cancellation of their probationary hearing.

The revised plan focuses on four key problems pointed out by Water Board staff: chronic lowering of groundwater levels; land subsidence; degradation of water quality and depletion of interconnected surface water.

Groundwater agencies also opened their pocketbooks to address impacts that lowered groundwater levels have on domestic wells. The crown jewel of the revised plan is a $5.8 million domestic well protection program in cooperation with Visalia-based nonprofit Self-Help Enterprises, hailed by drinking water advocates as a beacon for other subbasins to follow.

Managers have returned to the drawing board on that program, though, as state funding challenges have threatened the GSAs' ability to assist residents whose wells have gone dry.

Some projects in East Kaweah Groundwater Sustainability Agency are funded by the state Multibenefit Land Repurposing Program.

Fukuda gave credit to the consultants who have worked alongside basin managers Mark Larsen of

"Kaweah Groundwater Basin" continued on page 14

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Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

California's Detector Dog Team Program

The California Agriculture Detector Dog Program was developed to enhance statewide pest detection efforts in preventing the introduction of harmful plant pests into the State of California via parcel shipments. Studies indicate that new potentially damaging invasive species become established in California approximately every 60 days. UC-Riverside's Center for Invasive Species Research estimates the economic losses from invasive pests introduced to California are $3 billion per year. By intercepting invasive pests before they can become established, dog teams are enhancing our ability to protect California's $51 billion agriculture industry and the environment.

Owen is an enthusiastic and dedicated worker who is always eager to please.

Detector dog Owen with one of his finds: a bag of peaches.

Detector dog teams are stationed in Alameda, Contra Costa, Fresno, Los Angeles, Sacramento, San Diego, Santa Barbara and Santa Clara counties in California to help find invasive pests hitchhiking in packages and cargo. The dogs go through many weeks of training with their handlers, learning to sniff out materials that could harbor invasive species including fruit, plants, and soil. On the job, dogs alert their handlers if they smell these target odors inside packages. Trained biologists then inspect the packages for pests like insects and plant diseases that could be harmful to crops or the environment. The Detector Dog Team Program is a cooperative effort between the California Department of Food and Agriculture (CDFA), County Agricultural Commissioners, and the U.S. Department of Agriculture.

Soya helps with inspections to find exotic pests at terminal/ parcel facilities.

In fiscal year (FY) 2021 (July 1, 2021-June 30, 2022) the California Dog Teams continued to demonstrate that unmarked parcels present a high–risk pathway for significant agricultural pests to enter California. During the FY 2021, a total of 966 significant pests were intercepted by California Dog Teams. Some of these interceptions involved multiple pest specimen in a single package. The detector dogs alerted on parcels that yielded pests that are known to cause serious agricultural and economic impacts such as Caribbean fruit fly, Cedar and Japanese apple rusts, federally actionable weed species including Hydrilla, and several first–detected fungi, and noxious weeds not known to occur in California and the United States.

The U.S. Department of Agriculture's Animal Plant Health Inspection Service Plant Protection and Quarantine Program (APHIS-PPQ) trains dog teams for the U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) inspections under the Agricultural Quarantine Inspection (AQI) program to conduct international inspections at our nation's points of entry. Trained dogs and their handlers also work for State departments of agriculture (California, Florida, Hawaii, North Carolina, & territory of Guam), county agricultural commissioners and foreign agricultural ministries. These agencies use the detector dog teams to conduct domestic inspections in warehouses, mail and package facilities to identify plant and agricultural materials inside packages, as well as other pest detection efforts. Funding for these programs is provided through the Plant Protection Act (7 USC 7721) authorized in the 2014 Farm Bill and annual discretionary funding APHIS receives from Congress.

Detector dogs and their human handlers are trained by APHIS at the National Detector Dog Training Center (NDDTC) in Newnan, Georgia. Currently California has 13 active dog teams located in 9 counties. The teams work regionally with access to more than 200 facilities in 32 of California's 58 counties The teams are distributed based on potential impacts of pest introduction, density of parcel facilities, and cultural diversity.

A 2024 study commissioned by the California Agricultural Commissioner and Sealer Association (CACASA) shows the optimum number of detector dog teams that should be operating in the nation's largest agricultural state should be a minimum 21 teams. CACASA supports and is committed to advocating for funding for additional dog teams.

CBP and state's detector dog team programs are challenged due to attrition, ongoing retirements of dogs and logistics of one Center providing the training for the nation. The Newnan, GA facility should continue as the national HQ, but there needs to be more training facilities closer to the proximity where the dog teams and their handlers will ultimately be deployed.

Continuous and adequate funding is necessary to keep this biological program functioning at a minimal level of 21 teams. At this level California's Detector Dog Team Program requires a minimum $7.5 million annually in base funding and for certification, training and additional programs.

Learn how trained dogs help protect California from invasive pests. Visit the Detector Dog Team website at cdfa.ca.gov/plant/dogteams/. For more information or any questions, please contact the Kings County Department of Agriculture, agstaff@co.kings.ca.us, (559) 852-2830.

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"Groundwater Management" continued from page 1

charges will now be included and are expected to collectively contribute over half a million dollars.

For large pumpers, the cost doubles. The proposal presents this as a move toward fairness by linking fees to the amount of groundwater extracted. However, in practice, it imposes significantly higher costs on a small number of users without explaining how enforcement expenses are calculated or whether they align with actual use or basin-specific activities.

Who's Paying for What?

Technical staff time spent in Kern, Chowchilla, Tulare Lake, and Kaweah is being billed to Tule Basin. Tule is acting as the billing catch-all, despite limited engagement or benefits from that time. This raises serious concerns about double billing, cost fairness, and the lack of itemized accounting.

Accountability mechanisms are missing. There are no published standards for how staff time is distributed across basins or how enforcement actions are monitored. Public documentation on fee revenue usage, reserve amounts, or the duration of probationary oversight is unavailable. Stakeholders cannot verify if the SGMA program operates effectively or fairly.

What About the Tulare Lake Subbasin?

Currently, the Tulare Lake Subbasin is not paying these fees due to a legal challenge filed by the Kings County Farm Bureau. That lawsuit is actively protecting Tulare stakeholders from the same financial burden that the Tule Subbasin faces. This protection is temporary, but significant. Without it, Tulare Lake would already be subject to the new fee structure and potentially contributing millions to the State's program.

Because the same fee model would apply across the state, adding Tulare Lake would double SGMA revenue without changing the program's actual budget. This raises legitimate questions: If enforcement expands, where does the extra money go? What guardrails are in place to ensure fees stay proportional to need?

Probation Without a Path Out

Probation is intended to be a temporary status, an alert that a basin's sustainability efforts need improvement. Once a basin is placed under State oversight, the path forward becomes unclear.

There is no defined process outlining what actions lead to compliance, how progress is measured, or when fees might be reduced. This leaves local agencies trying to navigate enforcement without a roadmap or shared understanding of what success requires.

Without clear goals or limits, probation can begin to look less like a corrective measure and more like a long-term funding stream. As more basins are added and no system exists to adjust fees accordingly, the total amount collected could exceed what the program needs. That raises genuine concerns about fairness, and it's precisely why public input is crucial.

In Closing

This is more than just a water issue. It's about how decisions are made and who has the authority to make them. The policies being shaped now will determine not only how groundwater is measured and paid for, but also who has a voice in managing it. The agricultural community has long been the backbone of this region, and it deserves a transparent, fair, and locally grounded system of governance. SGMA was intended to support local control. That control is only real if we show up, ask tough questions, and make our views known, while we still can.

Right now, the Kings County Farm Bureau is asking those questions in court. Their legal challenge is forcing the State to clarify its authority, its budget, and its obligations to the people who live and work in this basin. That effort is critical, and it deserves broad support from those who will be most affected. A strong, unified voice from this region is the best way to ensure the decisions being made reflect both fairness and reality on the ground.

Julie Martella is a writer, educator, and SGMA consultant working at the intersection of groundwater policy, stakeholder engagement, and agricultural resilience in the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

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Kings County Rural Crime Report

Contributed by Detective Santos

In the month of June, the Rural Crimes Unit obtained multiple search warrants for illegal marijuana grows. In the 24000 block of 5 1/2 Ave in Corcoran, there were three search warrants granted for three separate properties. There was a total of 13 hoop houses with 1900 marijuana plants inside, which were destroyed, and six arrests were made.

These specific properties continue to grow illegal marijuana nearly every year and are also considered to be a nuisance. This year, we requested and were granted search warrants with a destruction order clause per the Kings County courts, which allowed us to destroy the hoop house structures. We were able to obtain a large loader from the County to assist us with destroying the hoop houses. The hoop houses were then left in a large pile, and the bill for the loader, including the man-hours, will be billed to the property owners. We believe this will dissuade the property owners from allowing renters/suspects to grow marijuana the following year.

In the 11500 block of 10 1/2 Ave in Hanford, approximately 450 marijuana plants were destroyed. While we were on scene, we were unable to locate any suspects on the property; therefore, no arrests were made.

We had a 2008 Jacobsen, dual axle, car hauler trailer, stolen from a dairy site in the area of 10 1/2 Ave and Lansing Ave. We are actively attempting to locate this trailer.

This month, we also had one copper wire theft, which was reported to us. In the area of 22nd Ave and Fremont Ave, approximately 20 feet of copper wire from a well pump was taken. The theft of wire and repairs are estimated to cost $7,000.

We are often asked what we (the AG community) can do to help with locating their stolen property. We have had success in the past with the community placing trackers on their equipment. The issue with some trackers is the size of the trackers, and suspects, at times, will locate them and then discard the tracker. The larger trackers typically work well on a large piece of equipment, such as a tractor, but for smaller equipment, it is too easy to be located.

Some people have begun to place Apple air tags on some of their property since they are approximately the size of a quarter. We found this to be a good idea, and we have recovered several pieces of equipment, including a trap wagon and a tractor. We suggest the community consider placing tracker devices on their equipment such as the Air tag or something similar to it. These obviously are not guaranteed to work 100% of the time, due to various reasons to include a malfunction or being located by the suspect but overall, they have been a crucial tool for us in law enforcement.

If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time.

Detective Santos (559) 904-6893

Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512

Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441

"GSA Roundup" continued from page 1

Meanwhile, well registration continues to rise, and growers are still pushing for greater representation. Subsidence limits and groundwater allocations are being finalized, with plans to trigger tighter controls if conditions worsen. Coordination with other GSAs remains limited, raising compliance concerns.

El Rico and Southwest Kings GSA

No meeting or updates available.

Final Notes

At all meetings, there was a detailed discussion about the State Water Board's proposed SGMA fee structure. While still in draft form, the proposal would shift toward a graduated fee system that places higher costs on larger pumpers. Stakeholders raised concerns about fairness, timing, and the potential impacts on working operations already managing steep groundwater reductions. No decisions were made, but the issue remains at the forefront for everyone in the basin.

Groundwater sustainability depends on more than a plan. It takes community involvement, honest conversations, and active participation. This month, we saw meaningful progress in some areas, alongside ongoing questions about funding, data, and who gets heard. If you're part of this basin, now's the time to stay involved.

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"Kaweah Groundwater Basin" continued from page 7

Greater Kaweah and Mike Hagman of East Kaweah.

Fukuda said many challenges remain for water managers, including how the state allocates surface water.

"We're basically managing the extraction of surface water," he said. "So, if the game changes on the surface water side, it's going to affect groundwater. But my goal is to give agriculture and communities a fair shot at the same future they had in the past, even though it's going to be a challenge."

Kaweah's revised GSP is posted on the DWR portal at https://sgma.water.ca.gov/portal/state/preview-intervention/4 and is open for a 75-day public comment period until Sept. 1.

According to a June 26 press release from DWR's Sustainable Groundwater Management Office, posting a GSP on the portal initiates a 75-day public comment period. However, DWR will not evaluate or assess any GSP from the Kaweah subbasin unless requested to do so by the water board or until the board notifies DWR that state intervention is complete and indicates jurisdiction be returned back to DWR. DWR will provide notice if it evaluates the GSP and will open a second public comment period.

Status of other basins

The six other San Joaquin Valley subbasins found to have inadequate plans are in varying stages of the enforcement process.

The Water Board has already placed two valley subbasins on probation, including Tulare Lake, which covers most of Kings County, and the Tule subbasin, which covers the southern half of Tulare County's flatlands.

The Kings County Farm Bureau sued the state and has so far been able to stave off probationary sanctions in the Tulare Lake subbasin. Probationary sanctions are just getting under way in the Tule subbasin.

The Water Board held Kern's probationary hearing in February and gave water managers more time to tweak that subbasin's plan, also noting substantial progress. Its next hearing is scheduled for Sept. 17.The Delta-Mendota subbasin will come before the board sometime this year. The Pleasant Valley subbasin just received an inadequate designation for its plan in February.

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